

FREE OWNER'S GUIDE

The Absentee Owner's Home-Watch Checklist

What to check on your Outer Banks home while you're away — and how often — so a small problem never becomes an expensive one.

If your OBX home sits empty for weeks or months, the coast doesn't wait. **Salt, humidity, wind, and storms work on a vacant house every single day** — and most insurers expect someone to be checking on it. This is the same walk-through a professional home-watch visit follows. Use it yourself, or let us handle it and send you photo proof every time.

1 Inside the home

The damage you can't see from the street — leaks, pests, and humidity.

- ☐ Check ceilings, walls, and under sinks for **water stains or active leaks**
- ☐ Look and smell for **mold or mildew** — the #1 coastal vacant-home problem
- ☐ Confirm the **HVAC is running** and holding temperature/humidity
- ☐ Run water and **flush every toilet** to keep traps from drying out
- ☐ Check the **water heater and under appliances** for drips or corrosion
- ☐ Look for signs of **pests or rodents** (droppings, nests, chewed material)
- ☐ Confirm **refrigerator/freezer** are running and breakers haven't tripped
- ☐ Verify **doors and windows** are locked and undisturbed

2 Outside the home

Where coastal weather does its work first.

- ☐ Walk the **roof line and siding** for missing shingles or storm damage
- ☐ Check **gutters and downspouts** are clear and draining away from the foundation
- ☐ Look for **algae, mildew, and salt film** on siding, decks, and railings
- ☐ Inspect **decks, stairs, and handrails** for rot or loose boards
- ☐ Confirm **outdoor furniture, grills, and items** are secure or stored
- ☐ Check the **driveway and walkways** for hazards and debris buildup
- ☐ Note any **landscaping or yard cleanup** that's overdue

3 Storm-season extras (June–November)

Hurricane season changes the stakes. Add these before and after any storm.

- ☐ **Before a storm:** secure or store loose items, confirm shutters/coverings
- ☐ **Before a storm:** photograph the property's condition for your records
- ☐ **After a storm:** check for wind, water, and flood damage inside and out
- ☐ **After a storm:** confirm power is restored and HVAC restarted
- ☐ **After a storm:** clear debris before it causes drainage or pest issues

4 How often should someone check?

If your home is...	Recommended check frequency
Vacant off-season	Every 1–2 weeks (insurers often require this)
A vacation rental	Around each turnover, plus periodic deep checks
Occupied occasionally	Monthly, plus before and after every storm
Empty long-term	Weekly — risk and insurer expectations are highest

Why this matters more on the Outer Banks

Roughly 60% of OBX homes are owned by people who don't live here. Many home insurance policies **require periodic checks on vacant properties** — and a leak or mold problem caught on week one is a cleanup, not a renovation. A documented check is your proof, your peace of mind, and often your coverage.

★ Don't want to fly in to do this yourself?

That's exactly what we do. **OBX Lot Solutions** walks your property on your schedule and sends you a **photo report every visit** — so you always know your home is fine, without leaving home.

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+ One trusted local, everything your home needs

- 1 **We watch it.** Scheduled checks with photo proof — the foundation.
- 2 **We keep it clean.** Soft washing, pressure washing, gutters, and junk removal on a recurring plan — the coast brings the algae back every year.